

HELPFUL PARTNERS
Guard crabs scavenge debris, defend their cauliflower coral hosts against intruders, and occasionally help catch prey. The corals provide shelter, and the crabs share meals.

GUARD CRAB



SEA SNAKE HOTSPOT
Sea snakes are aquatic and give birth in the water to live young. They are venomous, hunting fish and similar prey. Around 17 species dwell on the reef, but their survival is threatened by habitat change and declining water quality.

OLIVE SEA SNAKE



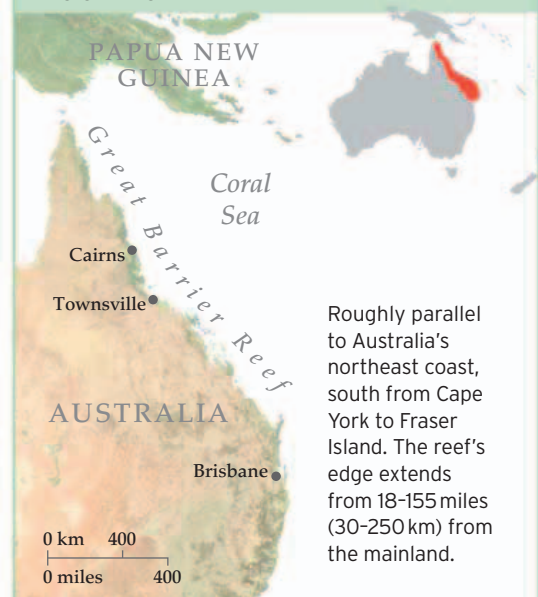
Covers roughly the same area as Japan

DELICATE BALANCE
Atmospheric carbon dioxide raises temperatures and dissolves in oceans, making seawater more acidic. Acid dissolves the coral's skeleton and can even prevent formation. The polyps die and leave behind a "bleached" appearance.

CORAL BLEACHING

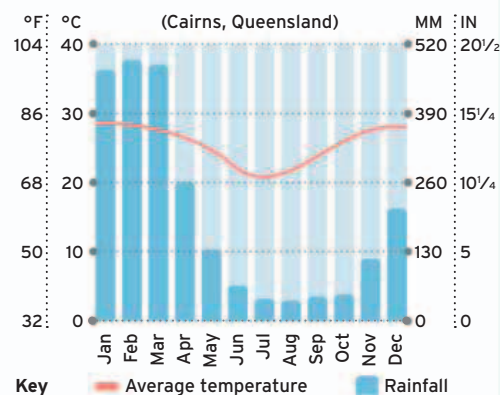


LOCATION



CLIMATE

Almost entirely within the tropic zone, the climate is moist and warm to hot most of the year, averaging 73-79°F (23-26°C), and rarely below 63°F (17°C) or above 90°F (32°C). In the wettest months of December to April, rain reduces the salinity of the more isolated lagoons.



LIFE ON THE REEF

Thousands of species live on the reef year-round, their numbers boosted by annual visitors such as humpback and dwarf minke whales. The smallest fish include permanent residents such as pygmy seahorses and gobies; the largest would be a passing whale shark.

